Preparing for the Job Search

CV, LinkedIn, Interviews, and the Job Talk

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CV Writing

Three Rules for Every Line of Your CV

1. Bold keyword first | **2.** Then a **verb** | **3.** No **jargon**

Before

Responsible for an R implementation of nonparametric sensitivity analysis for $I \times J$ contingency tables

After

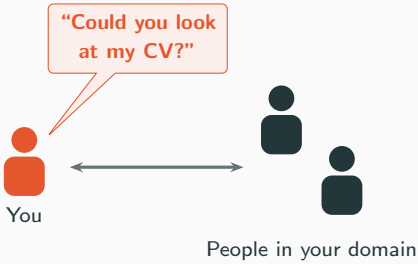
Software: Built an R package that checks whether study conclusions hold up against hidden bias

Applied impact: Analyzed national education data to study how prekindergarten affects math achievement

the bold keyword says what the line is about; the verb says what you did, in plain words

- A reader who only skims still sees the **keywords** (see my CV in Materials)

Ask People in Your Domain



Reach out and ask:

- What is the **preferred length** of a resume in this field?
- What does a **hiring manager** look at first?
- What would you change in **my draft**?

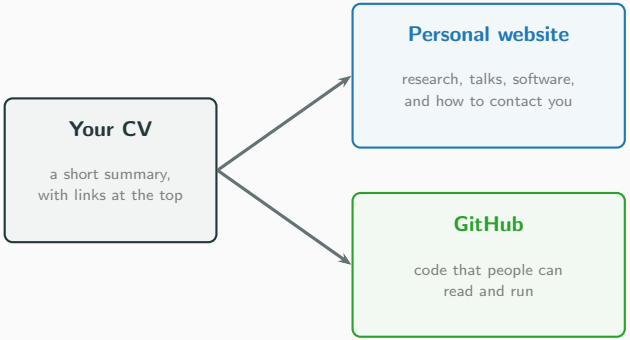
Conventions differ across fields, so the best advice comes from people who already work where you want to work.

Your CV Changes Over Time



- Lead with your **strongest evidence**, and ask for opinions again each time you update your CV

Go Beyond the CV: Website and GitHub

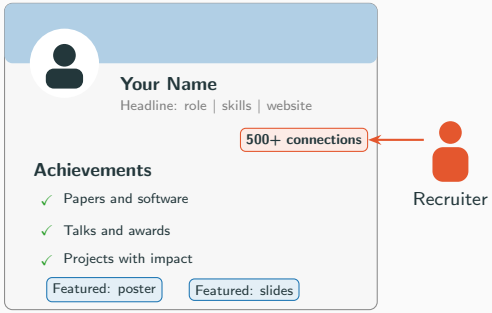


shows your work,
not only a description of it

- Build a **personal website** and a **GitHub** profile, and link both from your CV (see an example in Materials)

LinkedIn Preparation

LinkedIn Preparation



- **List your achievements**: papers, software, talks, awards, and projects
- Grow to **more than 500 connections**: your profile becomes more visible, and recruiters may come to you
- **Feature your work**, such as a poster or talk slides, so visitors can see it in one click (see Materials)

Short Interviews and Small Talk

Short Interviews: What to Expect

- Usually **20–45 minutes**, one-on-one or with a small panel
- The interviewer wants to learn three things:
  1. Can you explain your own work clearly?
  2. Are your technical fundamentals solid?
  3. Would you work well with the team?

Step 1: Know Your Own Resume

- For each project, prepare a **1–2 minute answer** covering:
  - The problem and why it matters
  - Your method and your own contribution
  - The result and its impact
- Expect follow-up questions:
  - "Why this method?"
  - "What would you do differently?"

Step 2: Refresh the Fundamentals

- Review core topics with short **online quizzes**
- Ask **scientists in your domain** which questions come up most often
- Practice explaining concepts **without notation**
- If one of your topics is likely to draw follow-up questions, prepare a **one-page poster** to walk through (see the poster tool)

Step 3: Prepare Questions for Them

- Most interviews end with "Do you have any questions for us?" Having none leaves a poor impression
- Look up each interviewer on **LinkedIn** beforehand, and bring notes on their title and background

Ask a manager

"What is the overall strategy for the team?"
"What makes a scientist successful on your team?"
"How could I grow here?"

Ask a scientist or junior colleague

"How did you learn [a skill the role needs]?"
"What is the team dynamic like?"

Self-Introduction

Preparing Your Self-Introduction

A strong self-introduction covers four points:

1. **Research focus**: what you work on, and how it can expand
2. **How you can help the team**: the concrete skills you bring
3. **How you see yourself contributing**: in the short and the long term
4. **Why this institution**: what draws you to join

Prepare two versions: a **2-minute** one and a **5-minute** one.

Self-Introduction: Research Focus

- Summarize your research in **one sentence**
- Explain how it can **expand** beyond your current work
- Connect it to **problems the team cares about**

Tool: A One-Page Poster of Your Self-Introduction



- Put the four points on **one page** that you can share on screen
- Keep each block to a few words and one picture
- Use it again when an interviewer asks more about one of your topics

See my poster in Materials.

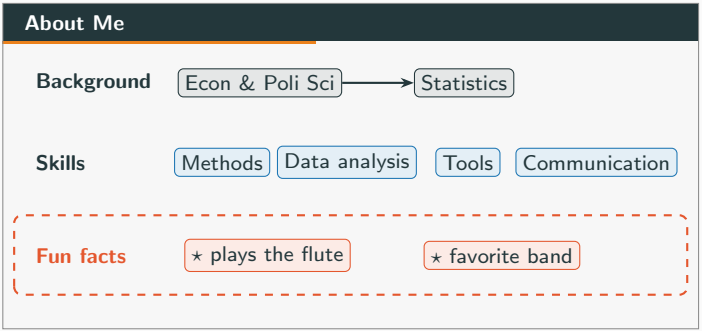
The Job Talk

Job Talk: Overview

1. Give a good introduction
2. Motivate the problem well
3. Give intuition for your model
4. Use color when steps are hard to follow
5. Show applications of your findings
6. Say that you want to join the team
7. Prepare backup slides
8. Practice many times, and **time yourself**

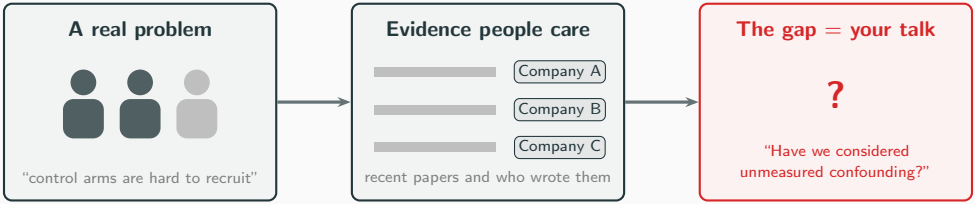
See my job talk slides in Materials.

Job Talk: Give a Good Introduction



- Share your **background and skills**, and add **two fun facts**: every team wants interesting colleagues

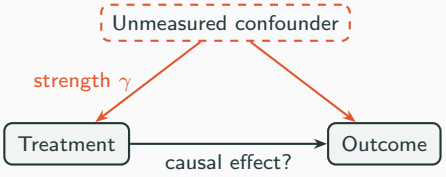
Job Talk: Motivate the Problem Well



- Start from a **question the audience cares about**: how does your work relate to what the team does, and why does it matter in industry?

Job Talk: Give Intuition for Your Model (If Any)

1 **Picture first**



2 **Formula second**

$$\mathbb{P}(Z_s = i) = \frac{\exp(\gamma\, \delta_i u_s)}{\sum_k \exp(\gamma\, \delta_k u_s)}$$

- Show a **picture or toy example first**, and let the visualization carry the idea

Job Talk: Use Color When Steps Are Hard to Follow (1/3)

A hard derivation (follow the cue)

1. **Notation**

s: subject i: treatment
u_s: unmeasured confounder

← *look here*

2. **Model** $\mathbb{P}(Z_s = i) = \dfrac{\exp(\gamma\, \delta_i u_s)}{\sum_k \exp(\gamma\, \delta_k u_s)}$

3. **Implication** $\text{odds ratio} = \exp\{\gamma(u_s - u_{s'})\} \;\leq\; e^{\gamma}$

- Color the **notation** first, so everyone can read what follows

Job Talk: Use Color When Steps Are Hard to Follow (2/3)

A hard derivation (follow the cue)

1. **Notation**

s: subject i: treatment
u_s: unmeasured confounder

2. **Model** $\mathbb{P}(Z_s = i) = \dfrac{\exp(\gamma\, \delta_i u_s)}{\sum_k \exp(\gamma\, \delta_k u_s)}$ ← *look here*

3. **Implication** $\text{odds ratio} = \exp\{\gamma(u_s - u_{s'})\} \;\leq\; e^{\gamma}$

- Then color **only the line** you are explaining right now

Job Talk: Use Color When Steps Are Hard to Follow (3/3)

A hard derivation (follow the cue)

1. **Notation**

s: subject i: treatment
u_s: unmeasured confounder

2. **Model** $\mathbb{P}(Z_s = i) = \dfrac{\exp(\gamma\, \delta_i u_s)}{\sum_k \exp(\gamma\, \delta_k u_s)}$

3. **Implication** $\text{odds ratio} = \exp\{\gamma(u_s - u_{s'})\} \;\leq\; e^{\gamma}$ ← *look here*

- The slide stays the same and the color moves, so the audience **always knows where to look**

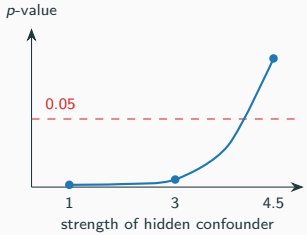
Job Talk: Show Applications of Your Findings

Real data

exposed	not
31	112
54	48
35	17

a published study

Your method applied



The decision

The finding holds unless a hidden confounder more than **triples** the odds

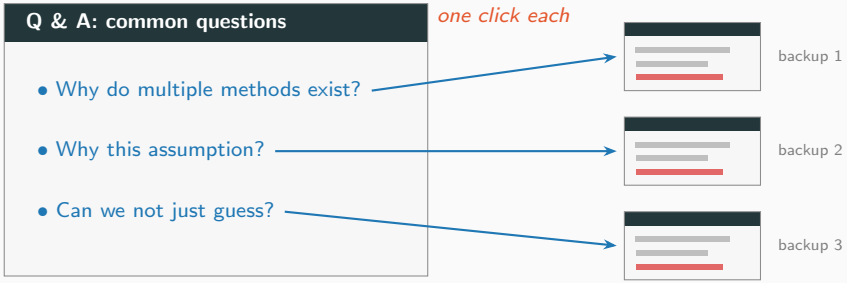
- Show how your findings **change a decision** in practice

Job Talk: Say That You Want to Join the Team



- End by **connecting your work to the team's**, and say clearly that you want to join

Job Talk: Prepare Backup Slides (1/3)



- **Anticipate the questions**: it shows preparation and a good attitude, and it impresses the audience

Job Talk: Prepare Backup Slides (2/3)

Why Do Multiple Sensitivity Analyses Exist? ← *title = the question*

Quantity of interest	Example paper
Regression coefficient	Paper A
ATT or ATE	Paper B
p-value in testing	Paper C

← *short, fair evidence*

However, here is when my approach is the most helpful one ← *end with your answer*

- Answer **one question per backup slide**, and finish with your own position

Job Talk: Prepare Backup Slides (3/3)

Why $u_s \in [0,1]$?

Sensitivity model $\mathbb{P}(Z_s = i) = \exp(\gamma\, \delta_i u_s) \,/\, \sum_k \exp(\gamma\, \delta_k u_s)$

Implication odds ratio $= \exp\{\gamma(u_s - u_{s'})\} \le e^{\gamma}$

The upper bound happens when $u_s = 1$, $u_{s'} = 0$:

$$\exp\{\gamma(u_s - u_{s'})\} = \exp\{\gamma(1-0)\} = e^{\gamma}$$

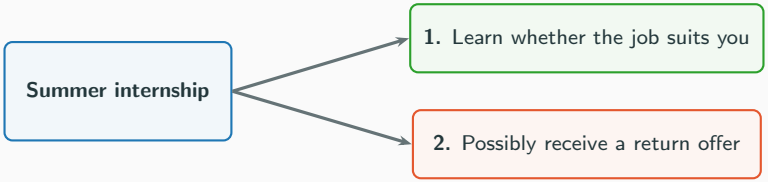
← *a slide they have already seen*

← *only the answer is in color*

- **Reuse a slide** from the main talk, and color only what is new

Internships and Finding the Right Fit

If Possible, Find a Summer Internship



Where to look:

- ASA Internships and Fellowships: the student page with the yearly internship list
- ASA STATtr@k: 2027 Internships
- ASA Career Connect: the job board

Compare Before You Decide

It is **not a waste of time** to compare:

- Working environment
- The team
- The job itself
- Salary and benefits

Where to find salary and benefits information:

- Levels.fyi: Statistician: pay reported for the statistician title
- Levels.fyi by industry: Pharmaceutical and Finance; see also Glassdoor for benefits by company
- ASA Salary Information: salary surveys of statisticians, including faculty
- U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics: official government data

Levels.fyi and Glassdoor are self-reported, so read them as a range.

Materials

Materials

Examples from my own job search (click to open):

CV
a bold keyword before each line

Job talk slides
my job talk on March 18, 2026

Canva poster
a one-page self-introduction

Personal website
research, software, presentations

Other links in this talk: where to look for internships and salary and benefits information.